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Selection and placement of safety mechanisms

Abstract

A method of designing a circuit includes identifying a first path from a first selected node of a circuit design. A first attribute is assigned to the first selected node. The method also includes identifying a second path from a second selected node of the circuit design. A second attribute is assigned to the second selected node. The method further includes determining a first intersection of the first path and the second path, selecting, by a processing device, a safety mechanism from a plurality of safety mechanisms based at least in part on the first attribute and the second attribute, and adding the safety mechanism to the circuit design at the first intersection.

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Background/Summary

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) The present disclosure relates to an electronic design automation (EDA) system and more particularly, to the selection and placement of safety mechanisms in electronic circuit designs.

BACKGROUND

(2) Integrated circuit (IC) chips may need to meet certain safety and quality standards. For example, chips used in automobiles may be subject to certain safety rules and standards to prevent catastrophic automobile accidents. These chips may include safety mechanisms that detect faults or errors in certain parts of the electronic circuit.

SUMMARY

(3) The present disclosure describes systems and methods for selecting and placing safety mechanisms into circuit designs. According to an embodiment, a method of designing a circuit includes identifying a first path from a first selected node of a circuit design. A first attribute is assigned to the first selected node. The method also includes identifying a second path from a second selected node of the circuit design. A second attribute is assigned to the second selected node. The method further includes determining a first intersection of the first path and the second path, selecting, by a processing device, a safety mechanism from a plurality of safety mechanisms based at least in part on the first attribute and the second attribute, and adding the safety mechanism to the circuit design at the first intersection.

(4) A third attribute may be assigned to the safety mechanism, and selecting the safety mechanism may be based at least in part on the third attribute matching at least one of the first attribute and the second attribute. The third attribute may include a diagnostic coverage percentage of the safety mechanism. The third attribute may include an indication of whether the safety mechanism is used on an encoder datapath or a decoder datapath.

(5) The method may include determining a second intersection of the first path and the second path. Adding the safety mechanism at the first intersection may be based at least in part on a comparison of one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the first intersection to one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the second intersection.

(6) The first selected node may be a pin, a wire, a flop, or a signal in the circuit design.

- (7) Identifying the first path and the second path may produce a cone of influence, and the first intersection may be an apex of the cone of influence.
- (8) According to another embodiment, a system for designing a circuit includes a memory and a processor communicatively coupled to the memory. The processor traces a first path from a first selected node of a circuit design. A first attribute is assigned to the first selected node. The processor traces a second path from a second selected node of the circuit design. A second attribute is assigned to the second selected node. The processor determines a first intersection of the first path and the second path, selects a safety mechanism from a catalog of safety mechanisms based at least in part on the first attribute and the second attribute, and adds the safety mechanism to the circuit design at the first intersection.
- (9) A third attribute may be assigned to the safety mechanism in the catalog, and selecting the safety mechanism may be based at least in part on the third attribute matching at least one of the first attribute and the second attribute. The third attribute may include a diagnostic coverage percentage of the safety mechanism. The third attribute may include an indication of whether the safety mechanism is used on an encoder datapath or a decoder datapath.
- (10) The processor may determine a second intersection of the first path and the second path. Adding the safety mechanism at the first intersection may be based at least in part on a comparison of one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the first intersection to one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the second intersection.
- (11) The first selected node may be a pin, a wire, a flop, or a signal in the circuit design.
- (12) Tracing the first path and the second path may produce a cone of influence, and the first intersection may be an apex of the cone of influence.
- (13) According to another embodiment, a non-transitory, computer readable medium stores instructions that, when executed by a processor, cause the processor to perform an operation for designing a circuit. The operation includes tracing a first path from a first node of a circuit design and a second path from a second node of the circuit design to produce a cone of influence. A first attribute is assigned to the first node, and a second attribute is assigned to the second node. The operation also includes determining a first apex of the cone of influence, selecting a safety mechanism from a catalog of safety mechanisms based at least in part on the first attribute and the second attribute, and adding the safety mechanism to the circuit design at the first apex of the cone of influence.
- (14) A third attribute may be assigned to the safety mechanism in the catalog, and selecting the safety mechanism may be based at least in part on the third attribute matching at least one of the first attribute and the second attribute. The third attribute may include a diagnostic coverage percentage of the safety mechanism. The third attribute may include an indication of whether the safety mechanism is used on an encoder datapath or a decoder datapath.
- (15) The operation may include determining a second apex of the cone of influence. Adding the safety mechanism at the first apex may be based at least in part on a comparison of one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the first apex to one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the second apex.
- (16) The first node may be a pin, a wire, a flop, or a signal in the circuit design.
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Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The disclosure will be understood more fully from the detailed description given below and from the accompanying figures of embodiments of the disclosure. The figures are used to provide knowledge and understanding of embodiments of the disclosure and do not limit the scope of the disclosure to these specific embodiments. Furthermore, the figures are not necessarily drawn to

scale.

(2) FIG. 1 illustrates an example system for selecting and placing safety mechanisms into a circuit design.

(3) FIG. 2 illustrates an example catalog of safety mechanisms in the system of FIG. 1.

(4) FIG. 3 illustrates how safety mechanisms are selected placed into an example circuit design in the system of FIG. 1.

(5) FIG. 4 is a flowchart of an example method for selecting and placing safety mechanisms into a circuit design performed in the system of FIG. 1.

(6) FIG. 5 illustrates an example apex selection in the system of FIG. 1.

(7) FIG. 6 is a flowchart of an example method for selecting an apex or intersection performed in the system of FIG. 1.

(8) FIG. 7 depicts a flowchart of various processes used during the design and manufacture of an integrated circuit in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

(9) FIG. 8 depicts a diagram of an example computer system in which embodiments of the present disclosure may operate.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(10) Aspects of the present disclosure relate to the automatic selection and placement of safety mechanisms. Certain integrated circuit (IC) chips include safety mechanisms that detect functional safety related faults or errors during the operation of the electronic circuit in the chip. For example, IC chips used in automobiles may include safety mechanisms that detect functional safety related faults or errors before these faults or errors lead to catastrophic automobile crashes. In existing electronic circuit design systems, these safety mechanisms are added to an electronic circuit design manually by a circuit designer. The circuit designer selects the safety mechanisms to add to the circuit design and the locations in the circuit design where the safety mechanisms are added. This process requires human judgment and subjectivity, which may result in incorrect safety mechanisms being selected or suboptimal placement of safety mechanisms.

(11) The present disclosure describes a system that automatically determines the safety mechanisms to add to a circuit design and the locations where the safety mechanisms are added. A circuit designer selects nodes in the circuit design and the system traces paths from the selected nodes to produce a cone of influence. The circuit design then determines an intersection of the traced paths originating from the nodes, which may be an apex of the cone of influence. The circuit designer may also have specified certain attributes for these selected nodes. The system references a catalog of safety mechanisms, which includes attributes for the safety mechanisms. The system selects a safety mechanism with attributes that match or are similar to the attributes of the selected nodes. The system then adds the selected safety mechanism to the intersection of the traced paths. In this manner, the system automatically selects and places the safety mechanism.

(12) In certain embodiments, the system provides several technical advantages. For example, the system may select correct safety mechanisms to use for different groups of nodes. Additionally, the system may optimally place the safety mechanisms in the circuit design to catch errors or fault. As a result, the system may produce circuit designs that are safer during operation (e.g., in an automobile).

(13) FIG. 1 illustrates an example system **100** for selecting and placing safety mechanisms into a circuit design. Generally, the system **100** may be an electronic circuit design system implemented by a computer system (e.g., the computer system **800** shown in FIG. 8). In particular embodiments, the system **100** automatically selects and places safety mechanisms into a circuit design, which improves the safety of the circuit during operation.

(14) The system **100** may receive or create a circuit design **102**. Generally, a circuit designer may use the system **100** to create or load the circuit design **102**. The circuit design **102** may indicate various circuit components and the connections between the circuit components. These circuit components or connections may be represented by nodes **104** in the circuit design **102**. As seen in

FIG. 1, the circuit design **102** includes nodes **104A** and **104B**. The circuit design **102** may include any suitable number of nodes **104**. The nodes **104** may represent any portion of the circuit design **102**. For example, the nodes **104** may represent pens, wires, flops, or signals in the circuit design **102**.

(15) The circuit designer may assign attributes to the nodes **104**. These attributes may indicate the types of circuit components or connections included within the nodes **104**. As a result, the attributes may indicate the types of errors or faults that may be relevant to the nodes **104**. For example, certain attributes may indicate whether a node **104** is part of an encoder path or a decoder path. As another example, some attributes may indicate whether a node **104** is part of a time-based circuit or a handshake-based circuit. In some embodiments, safety mechanisms are selected for a node **104** or a set of nodes **104** based on the attributes that are assigned the node **104** or the set of nodes **104**.

(16) The system **100** may identify or trace paths within the circuit design **102** to determine a cone of influence **106**. Generally, a circuit designer may select or specify various nodes **104** in the circuit design **102** from which the system **100** traces paths. When tracing a path from a selected node **104**, the system **100** determines the flow of an electric signal through the circuit design **102** starting from the selected node **104**. For each selected node **104**, the system **100** traces one or more paths from the selected node **104**. For example, if a signal branches as it flows from the selected node **104**, the system **100** may trace a path for each of the branches of the flow. The system **100** may then determine where in the circuit design **102** the various traced paths intersect. These points of intersection may be the endpoints of a cone of influence **106**. Each cone of influence **106** indicates the portions of the circuit design **102** that are covered by the traced paths that meet at the intersection. The system **100** may determine any suitable number of cones of influence **106** for each set of selected nodes **104**.

(17) The system **100** determines an apex **108** for each determined cone of influence **106**. The apex **108** for each cone of influence **106** may be the point of intersection of the traced paths that form the cone of influence **106**. In certain embodiments, the system **100** may place one or more safety mechanisms at the apex **108** of a cone of influence **106**. In some embodiments, if the traced paths that form a cone of influence **106** intersect at multiple points, then the cone of influence **106** is considered to have multiple apexes **108** and a subsequent evaluation using constraints (e.g., area or timing constraints) is performed to determine which apex **108** should be selected for placement of the safety mechanism.

(18) The system **100** may select one or more safety mechanisms **112** from a catalog **110** of safety mechanisms **112** to place at the apex **108**. As seen in FIG. 1, the catalog **110** includes any suitable number of safety mechanisms **112**. Generally, each safety mechanism **112** in the catalog **110** is assigned one or more attributes that describe the safety mechanism **112**. For example, a circuit designer may assign attributes that indicate the types of faults or errors that the safety mechanisms **112** detect. The system **100** may select one or more safety mechanisms **112** to place at an apex **108** based on the attributes assigned to the safety mechanisms **112**. For example, the circuit designer may have assigned certain attributes to the selected nodes **104** from which the cone of influence **106** was formed. The system **100** may compare the attributes assigned to the nodes **104** with the attributes assigned to the safety mechanisms **112** in the catalog **110**. The system **100** may select the safety mechanisms **112** that have attributes that match the attributes assigned to the nodes **104**. The system **100** then places the selected safety mechanisms **112** at the apex **108** of the cone of influence **106**. In this manner, the system **100** ensures that the correct safety mechanism **112** was selected for the selected nodes **104** and that the safety mechanism **112** was placed in an optimal position in the circuit design **102**, in certain embodiments.

(19) FIG. 2 illustrates an example catalog **110** of safety mechanisms in the system **100** of FIG. 1. As discussed previously, the catalog **110** includes any suitable number of safety mechanisms **112**. As seen in FIG. 2, the catalog **110** includes the safety mechanisms **112A**, **112B**, **112C**, **112D**, **112E**, and **112F**. Generally, each entry in the catalog **110** includes identifiers for a safety mechanism **112**

along with attributes that describe the safety mechanism **112**. For example, the attributes may describe the type of fault or error detected by the safety mechanism **112**. As another example, the attributes may describe a diagnostic coverage percentage of the safety mechanism **112**. The diagnostic coverage percentage may indicate a percentage of a particular type of faults or errors that the safety mechanism **112** checks or attempts to detect. A high diagnostic coverage percentage may indicate that the safety mechanism **112** checks for a larger number of faults or errors of a particular type.

(20) In the example of FIG. 2, the catalog **110** includes the safety mechanisms **112A**, **112B**, **112C**, **112D**, **112E**, and **112F**. The safety mechanism **112A** is identified by an identifier **SM1** and detects faults or errors in an error correction code (ECC) encoder. The entry in the catalog **110** also indicates that the safety mechanism **112A**, identified by an identifier **SM1**, is a non-clock type safety mechanism that checks for faults or errors in an encoder data path (Attribute1). The entry also indicates that the safety mechanism **112A** provides high diagnostic coverage (Attribute1). Specifically, the entry indicates that the diagnostic coverage of the safety mechanism **112A** is 99% (Attribute2).

(21) The entry for the safety mechanism **112B** indicates that the safety mechanism **112B** is identified by an identifier **SM2** and checks for faults or errors in an ECC decoder. The entry also indicates that the safety mechanism **112B** is a non-clock type safety mechanism that checks for faults or errors in a decoder data path (Attribute1). The entry further indicates that the safety mechanism **112B** provides high diagnostic coverage (Attribute1). Specifically, the safety mechanism **112B** provides a diagnostic coverage of 99% (Attribute2).

(22) The entry for the safety mechanism **112C** indicates that the safety mechanism **112C** is identified by an identifier **SM3** and checks for faults or errors in a parity encoder. The entry also indicates that the safety mechanism **112C** is a non-clock safety type mechanism that checks for faults or errors in an encoder datapath (Attribute1). The entry further indicates that the safety mechanism **112C** provides a medium level of diagnostic coverage (Attribute1). Specifically, the safety mechanism **112C** provides a diagnostic coverage of 87% (Attribute2).

(23) The entry for the safety mechanism **112D** indicates that the safety mechanism **112D** is identified by an identifier **SM4** and checks for faults or errors in a parity decoder. The entry also indicates that the safety mechanism **112D** is a non-clock type safety mechanism that checks for faults or errors in a decoder datapath (Attribute1). The entry further indicates that the safety mechanism **112D** provides a medium level of diagnostic coverage (Attribute1). Specifically, the safety mechanism **112D** provides a diagnostic coverage of 87% (Attribute2).

(24) The entry for the safety mechanism **112E** indicates that the safety mechanism **112E** is identified by an identifier **SM5** and checks for faults or errors as a watchdog timer. The entry also indicates that the safety mechanism **112E** is a temporal time-based type safety mechanism (Attribute1). The entry further indicates that the safety mechanism **112E** provides a diagnostic coverage of 90% (Attribute2).

(25) The entry for the safety mechanism **112F** indicates that the safety mechanism **112F** is identified by an identifier **SM6** and checks for faults or errors as a watchdog timer. The entry also indicates that the safety mechanism **112F** is a temporal handshake-based type safety mechanism (Attribute1). The entry further indicates that the safety mechanism **112F** provides a diagnostic coverage of 90% (Attribute2).

(26) When the system **100** selects a safety mechanism **112** from the catalog **110**, the system **100** may select a safety mechanism **112** with attributes that match the attributes of the selected nodes **104** from which the cone of influence **106** was formed. For example, if the selected nodes **104** have attributes that indicate that the selected nodes **104** are on a decoder datapath and need high diagnostic coverage, then the system **100** may select the safety mechanism **112B** for the selected nodes **104**. As another example, if the selected nodes **104** have attributes that indicate the selected nodes **104** are on an encoder datapath and require a medium level of diagnostic coverage, then the

system **100** may select the safety mechanism **112C** for the selected nodes **104**. In this manner, the system **100** selects the safety mechanism **112** from the catalog **110** that is most suitable for the selected nodes **104**, in particular embodiments.

(27) FIG. 3 illustrates how safety mechanisms are selected placed into an example circuit design **102** in the system **100** of FIG. 1. Generally, FIG. 3 shows the selection and placement of particular safety mechanisms **112** into the circuit design **102**. As seen in FIG. 3, certain nodes **104** of the circuit design **102** have been selected and cones of influence **106** have been formed from those selected nodes **104**. Specifically, a circuit designer has selected the nodes **104A**, **104B**, **104C**, **104D**, **104E**, **104F**, **104G**, **104H**, **104I**, **104I**, **104K**, and **104L**. The cones of influence **106A**, **106B**, **106C**, **106D**, **106E**, and **106F** have been formed from the selected nodes **104**.

(28) The circuit designer may have instructed the system **100** to identify paths starting from the nodes **104A** and **104B**, and in response, the system **100** may trace paths starting from the nodes **104A** and **104B**. As seen in FIG. 3, the nodes **104A** and **104B** may be input nodes to the circuit design **102**. Specifically, the node **104A** may be an input port that receives an enables signal for a receiver (rx_enable), and the node **104B** may be an input port that receives a data signal for the receiver (rx_data). The system **100** traces paths from the nodes **104A** and **104B** to form the cone of influence **106A**. The system **100** may have determined an intersection of the traced paths from the nodes **104A** and **104B** as the apex **108A** of the cone of influence **106A**. The system **100** may then compare the attributes **302A** assigned to the nodes **104A** and **104B** with the attributes of the various safety mechanisms **112** in the catalog **110**. In the example of FIG. 3, the system **100** determines that the attributes for the safety mechanism **112B** match the attributes **302A** for the nodes **104A** and **104B**. In response, the system **100** selects the safety mechanism **112B** and places the safety mechanism **112B** at the intersection or apex **108A** of the cone of influence **106A**.

(29) The circuit designer may have instructed the system **100** to identify paths starting from the nodes **104C** and **104D** to form the cone of influence **106B**, and in response, the system **100** traces paths starting from the nodes **104C** and **104D**. As seen in FIG. 3, the node **104C** may be a signal internal to the circuit design as a data interrupt signal for a transmitter (tx_data_int), and the node **104D** may be an internal enable signal for the transmitter (tx_enable). The system **100** may trace paths from the nodes **104C** and **104D** to form the cone of influence **106B**. The system **100** may determine an intersection of these traced paths as the apex **108B** of the cone of influence **106B**. The system **100** then compares the attributes **302B** of the nodes **104C** and **104D** with the attributes of the safety mechanisms **112** in the catalog **110**. The system **100** may determine that the safety mechanism **112A** has attributes that match the attributes **302B** of the nodes **104C** and **104D**. In response, the system **100** selects the safety mechanism **112A** and places the safety mechanism **112A** at the apex **108B** of the cone of influence **106B**.

(30) The circuit designer may instruct the system **100** to identify paths starting from the nodes **104E** and **104F** to form the cone of influence **106C**, and in response, the system **100** traces paths starting from the nodes **104E** and **104F**. As seen in FIG. 3, the node **104E** is an internal interrupt ready signal (int_ready), and the node **104F** is an internal interrupt enable signal (int_enable). The system **100** traces paths from the nodes **104E** and **104F** to form the cone of influence **106C** and determines an intersection of the traced paths as the apex **108C** of the cone of influence **106C**. The system **100** then compares the attributes **302C** of the nodes **104E** and **104F** with the attributes of the safety mechanisms **112** in the catalog **110**. The system **100** may determine that the safety mechanism **112E** has attributes that match the attributes **302C** of the nodes **104E** and **104F**. In response, the system **100** selects the safety mechanism **112E** and places the safety mechanism **112E** at the apex **108C** of the cone of influence **106C**.

(31) The circuit designer may instruct the system **100** to identify paths starting from the nodes **104G** and **104H** to form the cone of influence **106D**, and in response, the system **100** traces paths starting from the nodes **104G** and **104H**. As seen in FIG. 3, the node **104G** is an input port for a read data signal for the register (reg_rd_data), and the node **104H** is an internal read enable signal

for a register (reg_rd_enable). The system **100** may trace paths from the nodes **104G** and **104H** to form the cone of influence **106D** and determine an intersection of the traced paths as the apex **108D** of the cone of influence **106D**. The system **100** compares the attributes **302D** of the nodes **104G** and **104H** with the attributes of the safety mechanisms **112** in the catalog **110**. The system **100** may determine that the safety mechanism **112D** has attributes that match the attributes **302D** of the nodes **104G** and **104H**. In response, the system **100** selects the safety mechanism **112D** and places the safety mechanism **112D** at the apex **108D** of the cone of influence **106D**.

(32) The circuit designer may instruct the system **100** to identify paths starting from the nodes **104I** and **104J** to form the cone of influence **106E**, and in response, the system **100** traces paths starting from the nodes **104I** and **104J**. As seen in FIG. 3, the node **104I** is an internal write enable signal for a register (reg_wr_enable), and the node **104J** is an internal write data interrupt signal for the register (reg_wr_data_int). The system **100** traces paths from the nodes **104I** and **104J** to form the cone of influence **106E** and determines an intersection of the traced paths as the apex **108E** of the cone of influence **106E**. The system **100** then compares the attributes **302E** of the nodes **104I** and **104J** with the attributes of the safety mechanisms **112** in the catalog **110**. The system **100** may determine that the attributes of the safety mechanism **112C** match the attributes **302E** of the nodes **104I** and **104J**. In response, the system **100** selects the safety mechanism **112C** and places the safety mechanism **112C** at the apex **108E** of the cone of influence **106E**.

(33) The circuit designer may instruct the system **100** to identify paths starting from the nodes **104K** and **104L** to form the cone of influence **106F**, and in response, the system **100** traces paths starting from the nodes **104K** and **104L**. As seen in FIG. 3, the node **104K** is an output port for a data request signal (data_req), and the node **104L** is an input port for a data acknowledgement signal (data_ack). The system **100** may trace paths from the nodes **104K** and **104L** to form the cone of influence **106F** and determines that an intersection of the traced paths is the apex **108F** of the cone of influence **106F**. The system **100** compares the attributes **302F** of the nodes **104K** and **104L** with the attributes of the safety mechanisms **112** in the catalog **110**. The system **100** may determine that the attributes of the safety mechanism **112F** match the attributes **302F** of the nodes **104K** and **104L**. In response, the system **100** selects the safety mechanism **112F** and places the safety mechanism **112F** at the apex **108F** of the cone of influence **106F**.

(34) FIG. 4 is a flowchart of an example method **400** for selecting and placing safety mechanisms into a circuit design performed in the system **100** of FIG. 1. In particular embodiments, a computer system (e.g., the computer system **800** shown in FIG. 8) performs the method **400**. By performing the method **400**, the computer system automatically selects and places safety mechanisms **112** into a circuit design **102**.

(35) In **402**, the computer system receives selected nodes **104**. The nodes **104** may represent any suitable circuit components or signals in the circuit design **102**. A circuit designer may have selected these nodes **104** and instructed the computer system to trace paths from these selected nodes **104**. The circuit designer may also have assigned attributes **302** to these selected nodes **104**. The assigned attributes **302** may indicate the types of circuit components or signals included in the selected nodes **104**.

(36) In **404**, the computer system identifies paths from the selected nodes **104** by tracing paths from the selected nodes **104**. The path tracing can be in a forward or reverse direction. To trace the paths, the computer system may determine the flow of electric signals through the circuit design **102** starting from the selected nodes **104**. These traced paths may reveal a cone of influence **106** of these selected nodes **104**. The cone of influence **106** may indicate the circuit components or signals that are affected by changes to signals at the selected nodes **104**.

(37) In **406**, the computer system determines an intersection of the traced paths from the selected nodes **104**. The intersection may be a location in the circuit design **102** where the traced paths from the selected nodes **104** cross. In some embodiments, the computer system may designate this intersection as an apex **108** of the cone of influence **106**.

(38) In **408**, the computer system determines the attributes **302** of the selected nodes **104**. As discussed previously, the attributes **302** of the selected nodes **104** may have been assigned by the circuit designer. These attributes **302** may indicate the types of circuit components or signals included in the selected nodes **104**.

(39) In **410**, the computer system selects a safety mechanism **112** from a catalog **110**. The catalog **110** may include any suitable number of safety mechanisms **112**. The catalog **110** may also identify attributes for each of the safety mechanisms **112**. These attributes may have been assigned by a circuit designer or a designer of the catalog **110**. The attributes for the safety mechanisms **112** may indicate the types of faults or errors detected by the safety mechanisms **112**. In certain embodiments, the computer system selects from the catalog **110** the safety mechanisms **112** with attributes that match the attributes **302** of the selected nodes **104**. In **412**, the computer system adds the selected safety mechanism **112** to the circuit design **102** at the intersection of the traced paths from the selected nodes **104**. For example, the computer system may place the selected safety mechanism **112** at the apex **108** of the cone of influence **106** for the selected nodes **104**.

(40) FIG. 5 illustrates an example apex selection in the system **100** of FIG. 1. In some instances, paths from selected nodes **104** may branch within the circuit design **102**. As a result, the system **100** may determine that the traced paths from the selected nodes **104** intersect at multiple intersection points. When there are multiple intersection points, the system **100** may perform additional analysis to determine where to place a selected safety mechanism **112**. Generally, the system **100** may select an intersection point based on certain constraints (e.g., constraints provided by the circuit designer).

(41) As seen in FIG. 5, the system **100** has traced paths from the selected nodes **104M** and **104N** to form the cone of influence **106G**. The traced paths from the selected nodes **104M** and **104N** branch within the circuit design **102**. As a result, the system **100** determines that the traced paths from the selected nodes **104M** and **104N** intersect at three different points. As a result, the system **100** determines three different apexes **108G**, **108H**, and **108I** for the cone of influence **106G**.

(42) The system **100** may determine which of the apexes **108G**, **108H**, and **108I** should be selected when placing a safety mechanism **112**. For example, the system **100** may select an apex **108** based on certain constraints applied to the different traced paths. The example of FIG. 5 shows different examples in which an apex **108** is selected based on those constraints. As seen in FIG. 5, the traced paths that lead to the apex **108G** include 110 gates and a two nanosecond timing path delay. The traced paths that lead to the apex **108H** have 90 gates and a four nanosecond timing path delay. The traced paths that lead to the apex **108I** have 120 gates and a six nanosecond timing path delay. The system **100** may select one of these apexes **108G**, **108H**, and **108I** based on constraints on the gate counts or timing.

(43) In the first example, the circuit designer provided the constraint that the area for the selected apex **108** should have less than 115 gates. In response, the system **100** may review the traced paths and determine that the traced paths that lead to the apexes **108G** and **108H** include less than 115 gates. The system **100** may select the apex **108H**, because the traced paths that lead to the apex **108H** have the fewest number of gates that is within the **115** gate constraint.

(44) In a second example, the circuit designer provided the constraint that the timing of path delay be less than the five nanoseconds. The system **100** may review the timings of the traced paths from the selected nodes **104M** and **104N** and determine that the traced paths that lead to the apexes **108G** and **108H** have timings less than five nanoseconds. The system **100** may select the apex **108G**, because the traced paths that lead to the apex **108G** have the lowest timing that within the five nanosecond timing constraint.

(45) In the third example, the circuit designer provided the constraints that the area be less than 115 gates and that the timing be less than three nanoseconds. The system **100** may review the traced paths from the selected nodes **104M** and **104N** and determine that the traced paths that lead to the apex **108G** have less than 115 gates and a timing less than three nanoseconds. In response, the

system **100** may select the apex **108G**.

(46) After the system **100** selects the apex **108** based on the provided constraints, the system **100** may add selected safety mechanisms **112** to the selected apex **108**. In this manner, the system **100** selects an apex **108** when there are multiple apexes **108** available for the placement of the safety mechanisms **112**.

(47) In certain embodiments, when multiple apexes **108** equally satisfy the provided constraints, the system **100** may select any of the apexes for the placement of the safety mechanisms **112**. For example, the system **100** may randomly select one of the apexes **108** for the placement of safety mechanisms **112**. In some instances, the system **100** may ask the circuit designer to select from the apexes **108** that equally satisfy the constraints.

(48) FIG. **6** is a flowchart of an example method **600** for selecting an apex or intersection performed in the system **100** of FIG. **1**. In particular embodiments, a computer system (e.g., the computer system **800** of FIG. **8**) performs the method **600**. By performing the method **600**, the computer system selects an apex **108** based on provided constraints.

(49) In **602**, the computer system determines multiple intersections of traced paths from selected nodes **104**. The computer system may receive selected nodes **104** from a circuit designer. The computer system may then trace paths from the selected nodes **104**. The traced paths may branch in the circuit design and intersect at multiple places. The computer system may determine these multiple intersections of the traced paths.

(50) In **604**, the computer system compares aspects of the traced paths to certain constraints. These constraints may have been provided by the circuit designer, and the constraints may relate to any suitable aspect or feature of the circuit design **102**. For example, the constraints may relate to the area or a number of gates. As another example, the constraints may relate to a timing. The computer system compares the aspects of the traced paths to the provided constraints to see which of the traced paths satisfy the constraints. For example, the computer system may evaluate which of the paths have an area or a timing that satisfies the provided constraints. The computer system may then determine the apexes **108** of the traced paths that satisfy the provided constraints.

(51) In **606**, the computer system selects an intersection or apex **108** of paths that satisfy the provided constraints. For example, if the provided constraint is that the traced paths include a certain number of gates, then the computer system may select the intersection or apex **108** of the traced paths that include a number of the gates that is within the constraint. In some embodiments, when multiple paths equally satisfy a provided constraint, the computer system selects an intersection or apex **108** at random, or the computer system may request the circuit designer to select an intersection or apex **108**.

(52) FIG. **7** illustrates an example set of processes **700** used during the design, verification, and fabrication of an article of manufacture such as an integrated circuit to transform and verify design data and instructions that represent the integrated circuit. Each of these processes can be structured and enabled as multiple modules or operations. The term 'EDA' signifies the term 'Electronic Design Automation.' These processes start with the creation of a product idea **710** with information supplied by a designer, information which is transformed to create an article of manufacture that uses a set of EDA processes **712**. When the design is finalized, the design is taped-out **734**, which is when artwork (e.g., geometric patterns) for the integrated circuit is sent to a fabrication facility to manufacture the mask set, which is then used to manufacture the integrated circuit. After tape-out, a semiconductor die is fabricated **736** and packaging and assembly processes **738** are performed to produce the finished integrated circuit **740**.

(53) Specifications for a circuit or electronic structure may range from low-level transistor material layouts to high-level description languages. A high-level of representation may be used to design circuits and systems, using a hardware description language ('HDL') such as VHDL, Verilog, SystemVerilog, SystemC, MyHDL or OpenVera. The HDL description can be transformed to a logic-level register transfer level ('RTL') description, a gate-level description, a layout-level

description, or a mask-level description. Each lower representation level that is a more detailed description adds more useful detail into the design description, for example, more details for the modules that include the description. The lower levels of representation that are more detailed descriptions can be generated by a computer, derived from a design library, or created by another design automation process. An example of a specification language at a lower level of representation language for specifying more detailed descriptions is SPICE, which is used for detailed descriptions of circuits with many analog components. Descriptions at each level of representation are enabled for use by the corresponding systems of that layer (e.g., a formal verification system). A design process may use a sequence depicted in FIG. 7. The processes described by be enabled by EDA products (or EDA systems).

(54) During system design **714**, functionality of an integrated circuit to be manufactured is specified. The design may be optimized for desired characteristics such as power consumption, performance, area (physical and/or lines of code), and reduction of costs, etc. Partitioning of the design into different types of modules or components can occur at this stage.

(55) During logic design and functional verification **716**, modules or components in the circuit are specified in one or more description languages and the specification is checked for functional accuracy. For example, the components of the circuit may be verified to generate outputs that match the requirements of the specification of the circuit or system being designed. Functional verification may use simulators and other programs such as testbench generators, static HDL checkers, and formal verifiers. In some embodiments, special systems of components referred to as ‘emulators’ or ‘prototyping systems’ are used to speed up the functional verification.

(56) During synthesis and design for test **718**, HDL code is transformed to a netlist. In some embodiments, a netlist may be a graph structure where edges of the graph structure represent components of a circuit and where the nodes of the graph structure represent how the components are interconnected. Both the HDL code and the netlist are hierarchical articles of manufacture that can be used by an EDA product to verify that the integrated circuit, when manufactured, performs according to the specified design. The netlist can be optimized for a target semiconductor manufacturing technology. Additionally, the finished integrated circuit may be tested to verify that the integrated circuit satisfies the requirements of the specification.

(57) During netlist verification **720**, the netlist is checked for compliance with timing constraints and for correspondence with the HDL code. During design planning **722**, an overall floor plan for the integrated circuit is constructed and analyzed for timing and top-level routing.

(58) During layout or physical implementation **724**, physical placement (positioning of circuit components such as transistors or capacitors) and routing (connection of the circuit components by multiple conductors) occurs, and the selection of cells from a library to enable specific logic functions can be performed. As used herein, the term ‘cell’ may specify a set of transistors, other components, and interconnections that provides a Boolean logic function (e.g., AND, OR, NOT, XOR) or a storage function (such as a flipflop or latch). As used herein, a circuit ‘block’ may refer to two or more cells. Both a cell and a circuit block can be referred to as a module or component and are enabled as both physical structures and in simulations. Parameters are specified for selected cells (based on ‘standard cells’) such as size and made accessible in a database for use by EDA products.

(59) During analysis and extraction **726**, the circuit function is verified at the layout level, which permits refinement of the layout design. During physical verification **728**, the layout design is checked to ensure that manufacturing constraints are correct, such as DRC constraints, electrical constraints, lithographic constraints, and that circuitry function matches the HDL design specification. During resolution enhancement **730**, the geometry of the layout is transformed to improve how the circuit design is manufactured.

(60) During tape-out, data is created to be used (after lithographic enhancements are applied if appropriate) for production of lithography masks. During mask data preparation **732**, the ‘tape-out’

data is used to produce lithography masks that are used to produce finished integrated circuits.

(61) A storage subsystem of a computer system (such as computer system **800** of FIG. **8**) may be used to store the programs and data structures that are used by some or all of the EDA products described herein, and products used for development of cells for the library and for physical and logical design that use the library.

(62) FIG. **8** illustrates an example machine of a computer system **800** within which a set of instructions, for causing the machine to perform any one or more of the methodologies discussed herein, may be executed. In alternative implementations, the machine may be connected (e.g., networked) to other machines in a LAN, an intranet, an extranet, and/or the Internet. The machine may operate in the capacity of a server or a client machine in client-server network environment, as a peer machine in a peer-to-peer (or distributed) network environment, or as a server or a client machine in a cloud computing infrastructure or environment.

(63) The machine may be a personal computer (PC), a tablet PC, a set-top box (STB), a Personal Digital Assistant (PDA), a cellular telephone, a web appliance, a server, a network router, a switch or bridge, or any machine capable of executing a set of instructions (sequential or otherwise) that specify actions to be taken by that machine. Further, while a single machine is illustrated, the term “machine” shall also be taken to include any collection of machines that individually or jointly execute a set (or multiple sets) of instructions to perform any one or more of the methodologies discussed herein.

(64) The example computer system **800** includes a processing device **802**, a main memory **804** (e.g., read-only memory (ROM), flash memory, dynamic random access memory (DRAM) such as synchronous DRAM (SDRAM), a static memory **806** (e.g., flash memory, static random access memory (SRAM), etc.), and a data storage device **818**, which communicate with each other via a bus **830**.

(65) Processing device **802** represents one or more processors such as a microprocessor, a central processing unit, or the like. More particularly, the processing device may be complex instruction set computing (CISC) microprocessor, reduced instruction set computing (RISC) microprocessor, very long instruction word (VLIW) microprocessor, or a processor implementing other instruction sets, or processors implementing a combination of instruction sets. Processing device **802** may also be one or more special-purpose processing devices such as an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC), a field programmable gate array (FPGA), a digital signal processor (DSP), network processor, or the like. The processing device **802** may be configured to execute instructions **826** for performing the operations and steps described herein.

(66) The computer system **800** may further include a network interface device **808** to communicate over the network **820**. The computer system **800** also may include a video display unit **810** (e.g., a liquid crystal display (LCD) or a cathode ray tube (CRT)), an alphanumeric input device **812** (e.g., a keyboard), a cursor control device **814** (e.g., a mouse), a graphics processing unit **822**, a signal generation device **816** (e.g., a speaker), graphics processing unit **822**, video processing unit **828**, and audio processing unit **832**.

(67) The data storage device **818** may include a machine-readable storage medium **824** (also known as a non-transitory computer-readable medium) on which is stored one or more sets of instructions **826** or software embodying any one or more of the methodologies or functions described herein. The instructions **826** may also reside, completely or at least partially, within the main memory **804** and/or within the processing device **802** during execution thereof by the computer system **800**, the main memory **804** and the processing device **802** also constituting machine-readable storage media.

(68) In some implementations, the instructions **826** include instructions to implement functionality corresponding to the present disclosure. While the machine-readable storage medium **824** is shown in an example implementation to be a single medium, the term “machine-readable storage medium” should be taken to include a single medium or multiple media (e.g., a centralized or distributed database, and/or associated caches and servers) that store the one or more sets of instructions. The

term “machine-readable storage medium” shall also be taken to include any medium that is capable of storing or encoding a set of instructions for execution by the machine and that cause the machine and the processing device **802** to perform any one or more of the methodologies of the present disclosure. The term “machine-readable storage medium” shall accordingly be taken to include, but not be limited to, solid-state memories, optical media, and magnetic media.

(69) Some portions of the preceding detailed descriptions have been presented in terms of algorithms and symbolic representations of operations on data bits within a computer memory. These algorithmic descriptions and representations are the ways used by those skilled in the data processing arts to most effectively convey the substance of their work to others skilled in the art. An algorithm may be a sequence of operations leading to a desired result. The operations are those requiring physical manipulations of physical quantities. Such quantities may take the form of electrical or magnetic signals capable of being stored, combined, compared, and otherwise manipulated. Such signals may be referred to as bits, values, elements, symbols, characters, terms, numbers, or the like.

(70) It should be borne in mind, however, that all of these and similar terms are to be associated with the appropriate physical quantities and are merely convenient labels applied to these quantities. Unless specifically stated otherwise as apparent from the present disclosure, it is appreciated that throughout the description, certain terms refer to the action and processes of a computer system, or similar electronic computing device, that manipulates and transforms data represented as physical (electronic) quantities within the computer system's registers and memories into other data similarly represented as physical quantities within the computer system memories or registers or other such information storage devices.

(71) The present disclosure also relates to an apparatus for performing the operations herein. This apparatus may be specially constructed for the intended purposes, or it may include a computer selectively activated or reconfigured by a computer program stored in the computer. Such a computer program may be stored in a computer readable storage medium, such as, but not limited to, any type of disk including floppy disks, optical disks, CD-ROMs, and magnetic-optical disks, read-only memories (ROMs), random access memories (RAMs), EPROMs, EEPROMs, magnetic or optical cards, or any type of media suitable for storing electronic instructions, each coupled to a computer system bus.

(72) The algorithms and displays presented herein are not inherently related to any particular computer or other apparatus. Various other systems may be used with programs in accordance with the teachings herein, or it may prove convenient to construct a more specialized apparatus to perform the method. In addition, the present disclosure is not described with reference to any particular programming language. It will be appreciated that a variety of programming languages may be used to implement the teachings of the disclosure as described herein.

(73) The present disclosure may be provided as a computer program product, or software, that may include a machine-readable medium having stored thereon instructions, which may be used to program a computer system (or other electronic devices) to perform a process according to the present disclosure. A machine-readable medium includes any mechanism for storing information in a form readable by a machine (e.g., a computer). For example, a machine-readable (e.g., computer-readable) medium includes a machine (e.g., a computer) readable storage medium such as a read only memory (“ROM”), random access memory (“RAM”), magnetic disk storage media, optical storage media, flash memory devices, etc.

(74) In the foregoing disclosure, implementations of the disclosure have been described with reference to specific example implementations thereof. It will be evident that various modifications may be made thereto without departing from the broader spirit and scope of implementations of the disclosure as set forth in the following claims. Where the disclosure refers to some elements in the singular tense, more than one element can be depicted in the figures and like elements are labeled

with like numerals. The disclosure and drawings are, accordingly, to be regarded in an illustrative sense rather than a restrictive sense.

Claims

1. A method of designing a circuit, the method comprising: identifying a first path from a first selected node of a circuit design, wherein a first attribute is assigned to the first selected node; identifying a second path from a second selected node of the circuit design, wherein a second attribute is assigned to the second selected node; determining a first intersection of the first path and the second path; selecting, by a processing device, a safety mechanism from a plurality of safety mechanisms based at least in part on the first attribute and the second attribute; and adding the safety mechanism to the circuit design at the first intersection.
2. The method of claim 1, wherein a third attribute is assigned to the safety mechanism, and wherein selecting the safety mechanism is based at least in part on the third attribute matching at least one of the first attribute and the second attribute.
3. The method of claim 2, wherein the third attribute comprises a diagnostic coverage percentage of the safety mechanism.
4. The method of claim 2, wherein the third attribute comprises an indication of whether the safety mechanism is used on an encoder datapath or a decoder datapath.
5. The method of claim 1, further comprising determining a second intersection of the first path and the second path, wherein adding the safety mechanism at the first intersection is based at least in part on a comparison of one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the first intersection to one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the second intersection.
6. The method of claim 1, wherein the first selected node is a pin, a wire, a flop, or a signal in the circuit design.
7. The method of claim 1, wherein identifying the first path and the second path produces a cone of influence, and wherein the first intersection is an apex of the cone of influence.
8. A system for designing a circuit, the system comprising: a memory; and a processor communicatively coupled to the memory, the processor configured to: trace a first path from a first selected node of a circuit design, wherein a first attribute is assigned to the first selected node; trace a second path from a second selected node of the circuit design, wherein a second attribute is assigned to the second selected node; determine a first intersection of the first path and the second path; select a safety mechanism from a catalog of safety mechanisms based at least in part on the first attribute and the second attribute; and add the safety mechanism to the circuit design at the first intersection.
9. The system of claim 8, wherein a third attribute is assigned to the safety mechanism in the catalog, and wherein selecting the safety mechanism is based at least in part on the third attribute matching at least one of the first attribute and the second attribute.
10. The system of claim 9, wherein the third attribute comprises a diagnostic coverage percentage of the safety mechanism.
11. The system of claim 9, wherein the third attribute comprises an indication of whether the safety mechanism is used on an encoder datapath or a decoder datapath.
12. The system of claim 8, wherein the processor is further configured to determine a second intersection of the first path and the second path, wherein adding the safety mechanism at the first intersection is based at least in part on a comparison of one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the first intersection to one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the second intersection.
13. The system of claim 8, wherein the first selected node is a pin, a wire, a flop, or a signal in the circuit design.
14. The system of claim 8, wherein tracing the first path and the second path produces a cone of

influence, and wherein the first intersection is an apex of the cone of influence.

15. A non-transitory, computer readable medium storing instructions that, when executed by a processor, cause the processor to perform an operation for designing a circuit, the operation comprising: tracing a first path from a first node of a circuit design and a second path from a second node of the circuit design to produce a cone of influence, wherein a first attribute is assigned to the first node, and wherein a second attribute is assigned to the second node; determining a first apex of the cone of influence; selecting a safety mechanism from a catalog of safety mechanisms based at least in part on the first attribute and the second attribute; and adding the safety mechanism to the circuit design at the first apex of the cone of influence.

16. The medium of claim 15, wherein a third attribute is assigned to the safety mechanism in the catalog, and wherein selecting the safety mechanism is based at least in part on the third attribute matching at least one of the first attribute and the second attribute.

17. The medium of claim 16, wherein the third attribute comprises a diagnostic coverage percentage of the safety mechanism.

18. The medium of claim 16, wherein the third attribute comprises an indication of whether the safety mechanism is used on an encoder datapath or a decoder datapath.

19. The medium of claim 15, wherein the operation further comprises determining a second apex of the cone of influence, wherein adding the safety mechanism at the first apex is based at least in part on a comparison of one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the first apex to one or more of an area and a timing of the circuit design to the second apex.

20. The medium of claim 15, wherein the first node is a pin, a wire, a flop, or a signal in the circuit design.
